

What We Bring to the Text Without Knowing It

The most powerful assumptions are the ones nobody states. Every reader carries a culture into Scripture, and the Western reader carries one too. The first step is admitting we have an accent.

THE FRAME

What Goes Without Saying

Every act of communication leaves most of itself unsaid. When I tell my sons we are leaving at nine, I do not specify morning, or that shoes are expected. It goes without saying, because we share a world. E. Randolph Richards and Brandon O'Brien built a whole book on this observation. The Bible's writers also left things unsaid, the things that went without saying between them and their first readers. And when we read, we do not leave those gaps empty. We fill them, instantly and invisibly, with what goes without saying for us.

That is the mechanism of misreading. Not bad motives. Not poor translation. Autofill.

The deepest assumptions are the ones we cannot see because we see by them, the way an eye cannot look at itself. Individualism, our sense of time, our defaults about money and race, the conviction that our way of reading is just reading. None of this announces itself. It simply shows up in the meaning we walk away with, and we credit the result to the Holy Spirit. This guide is an attempt to look at the eye.

CASE STUDY

Plans to Prosper You. Which You.

Jeremiah 29:11 may be the most quoted verse in American Christianity. For I know the plans I have for you, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We print it on graduation cards and gym bags, a personal promise of a bright individual future.

Read the chapter. The verse sits inside a letter to a community of exiles deported to Babylon, and the you is plural. Two verses earlier comes the part the cards omit. When seventy years are completed for

Babylon, I will visit you. Seventy years. The generation receiving the letter is told to build houses, plant gardens, marry off children, and seek the welfare of the enemy city, because most of them will die before the promise lands. The future and the hope belong to the people, kept across generations, not to any one exile's career.

Is the verse still good news. Better news, actually. A God who keeps promises to a people across seventy years of rubble is sturdier comfort than a God who guarantees my five-year plan. But it is not the news on the card. We shrank the promise to fit the recipient we assumed.

ASSUMPTION ONE

Time Is Not a Spreadsheet

Western readers live by the clock and the timeline, and we bring both to the text. So we are bothered that the Gospels order events differently, that Matthew arranges teaching by theme while Luke arranges by a long road to Jerusalem. We treat these as errors or puzzles to harmonize, because for us accurate means chronological.

The biblical writers were doing something else. Ancient authors arranged material the way a preacher arranges a sermon, for meaning, and their first readers knew it and were not scandalized. Scripture also cares about kinds of time we barely have words for, the right time, the full time, the day of the Lord, time as ripeness rather than sequence. When Paul says that at the right time Christ died for the ungodly, he is not reading a calendar. He is reading a harvest.

James tells the merchants planning next year's profits that they do not know what tomorrow will bring, that their life is a mist. He is not against planning. He is against the assumption underneath ours, that time is inventory and it is mine.

ASSUMPTIONS TWO AND THREE

The Faces and the Wallets We Assume

Two more defaults ride along quietly. The first is ethnic. Generations of Western art trained us to picture biblical people as Europeans, and the assumption survives the correction. The Bible's world runs from Africa through the Middle East, and the book never lets ethnicity disappear. An African court official is reading Isaiah in his chariot in Acts 8 and becomes one of the first baptized believers. The vision of Revelation is every nation, tribe, people, and language, and treating that as decoration rather than destination is a Western habit, not a biblical one.

The second is economic. Most readers of this guide, the writer included, are rich by the standards of every century before ours. So we spiritualize the Bible's money texts by reflex. The poor become the poor in spirit in passages that never say so. Jesus talked about wealth more than almost any other moral subject, and the early church heard those texts as people who knew hunger. We hear them through

insulation. When the text says woe to you who are rich, our first instinct is to think of someone richer. That instinct is data.

THE PRACTICE

How to Catch Yourself

There is no neutral reading and no escape from having a culture. But there are old, unglamorous disciplines that make the invisible visible.

Read with the global church. Commentaries, sermons, and friendships from outside the West will catch your reflexes faster than introspection ever will, because what goes without saying for you does not go without saying for a believer in Nairobi or Manila. Read slowly, and reread, because autofill operates at speed. Let the strange stay strange. When a text offends or baffles you, do not sand it down to something agreeable. The offense is often the doorway. Ask of every passage what had to be true in that world for this sentence to make sense. And check the pronouns.

One warning, and it is the point of everything above. Context can curdle into a new elitism, readers armed with backgrounds looking down on readers armed only with faith. That is misreading of another kind. The goal was never to stand over the text or over anyone else. The goal is to hear what was actually said, and then to be the kind of people who obey it. The Bible has survived all of our accents. The question is whether we will let it correct ours.

KEY TEXTS

Jeremiah 29:10-14

Acts 8:26-39

James 4:13-15

SOURCES

Misreading Scripture with Western Eyes — E. Randolph Richards and Brandon J. O'Brien

Jesus Through Middle Eastern Eyes — Kenneth E. Bailey

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva

The 3D Gospel: Ministry in Guilt, Shame, and Fear Cultures — Jayson Georges